

Read Me My Rights

A look at the digital world's newest bitter truth—DRM

Nimish Chandiramani

Digital Rights Management is a good thing. That's what *They* keep telling us. It "protects the creators," fights piracy, and most importantly, gets *Them* the money *They've* been crying about while the world wantonly shares *Their* content over the P2P networks. The debate over DRM—specifically for music and movies—now rivals in proportion such favourites as Paid versus Open Source software and "Does No *really* mean No?" As the war against piracy gets more frustrating, content creators get fiercer in the measures they take to protect their work, and it seems that whether we like it or not, DRM is going to be one of those inconvenient realities we have to deal with.

The definition, of course, is as harmless as can be—defining limitations to media to ensure the artists' / creators' intellectual property isn't misused. In theory, then, DRM is basically an implementation of the Copyright Act of the country

—instead of telling people they can't do something and then *hoping* they won't breach the law, why not ensure that the media prevents its own misuse? All this makes complete sense, too—at least while companies aren't thinking up newer and more boneheaded schemes to implement it (remember the Sony rootkit incident?). Before we jump to any conclusions about the goods, bads and uglies, let's spend a while understanding how this whole system works.

Brass Tacks

At the heart of every DRM technology is cryptography. The media (music, videos, software, even documents) is encrypted until unlocked with a "key"—a string of data that enables reversing the encryption (for more on cryptography, see box *Cryptography*). You should find this familiar—we've all used software that asked us for a serial key to run it. If you find *that* familiar, you'll

also recall how easy it was to crack those systems. The Request Code-Autho-
risation Code system came soon, where the software would "phone home" with a request code,

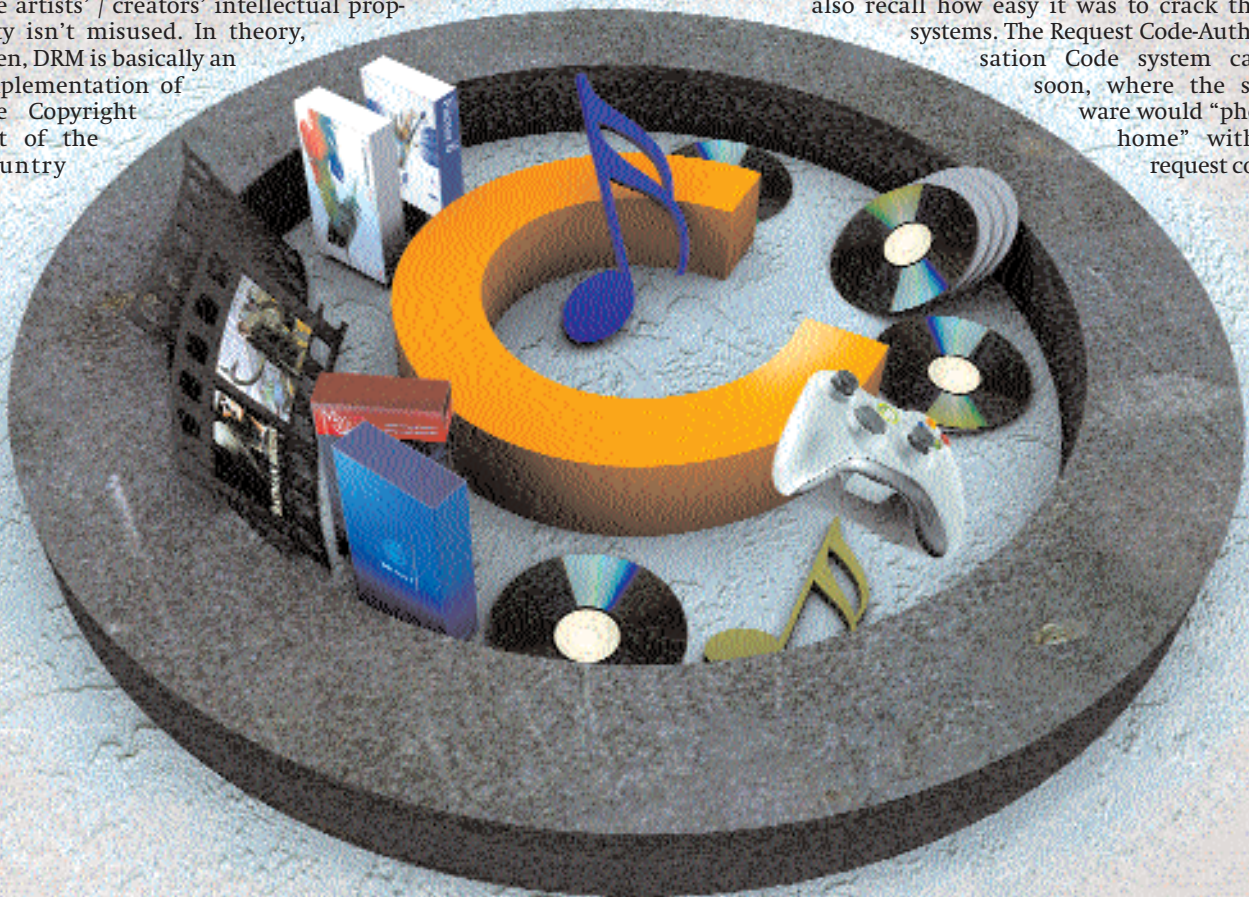


Illustration Pradip Ingale